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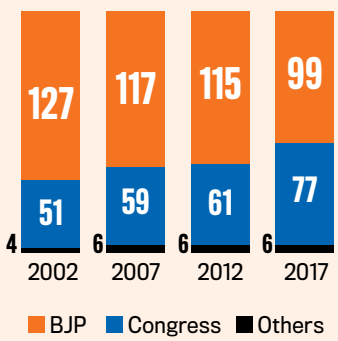
ANI

ONSTAGE (Left) PM Modi waves to crowds at the Khadi Utsav event as CM Patel watches; Kejriwal with AAP leaders at a tiranga yatra in Mehsana in June

DECEMBER DANDIYA

The BJP's seats have been going down with each election in Gujarat. Can the Congress catch up this time?

TOTAL SEATS 182



pedestrians on the Sabarmati river and joining a Khadi Utsav event where he spun a charkha with 7,500 women artisans from across Gujarat. All this hectic activity, of course, came against the backdrop of two important developments in the state. Barely 10 days before, on August 19, there had been a major overhaul of the state cabinet headed by Chief Minister Bhupendrabhai Patel. Then there was the controversial Independence Day 'gesture' from the state government, releasing 11 people convicted of involvement in the gang rape of Bilkis Bano and the murder of 14 members of her family in the 2002 communal attacks. A BJP source says Modi was in a huddle with state leaders, taking stock of the fallout of the two developments.

On August 19, CM Patel had stripped two of his ministers of important portfolios. Rajendra Trivedi lost revenue while Purnesh Modi had to give up roads and buildings. No official explanation has been given for the move but a BJP source said glibly that the leadership was in no mood to give the opposition a chance to point fingers when it comes to "inefficiency and shielding culprits" so close to the election. Trivedi, the No. 2 in the cabinet, had a penchant for live telecasting his "raids" on government officials (the buzz is he rubbed too many people the wrong way) while Purnesh Modi is in the dock for shielding a contractor responsible for faulty work on bridges. Both ministers, however, continue to hold a number of less important portfolios.

This isn't the first time such action has been taken. In March, the Prime Minister's Office (PMO) had asked the CM to dismiss his personal assistant, Dhrumil Patel. Then, in July, state BJP president C.R. Patil was asked to sack assistant Sudhanshu Mehta after receiving corruption complaints.

The BJP has had an uninterrupted stint in Gujarat for close to three decades, but the years have taken their toll with anti-incumbency and corruption scandals. They still have many things going for them this election—Modi, whose image shines bright as usual, a strong party organisation, a relatively efficient administration and, most importantly, an opposition Congress which is in a shambles. The last has largely been due to the BJP's poaching at regular intervals; many senior leaders, including 13 of the Congress's 77 MLAs, have crossed over in the past four and a half years. Ex-legislator and former AICC member Naresh Raval was the latest to go on August 18.

CM Patel, who has been in the